extreme inequalities of wealth and incomes and the growing urban–rural divide. Here was a path to modernity without the negative baggage carried by the predatory West. As we have seen, even within the rival KMT, the Soviet model was instrumental in transforming it as a powerful and coherent instrument for unifying the country.

India went through a similar phase of responding to the Western challenge, but there are important differences. As a country fully colonized by Britain, its administration and governance were in the hands of the colonial masters. In China, administration remained in the hands of the Chinese, except in the concessions located on the coast. The Chinese government retained agency throughout this period in a manner that Indians did not.

In China, whatever the debate on how to respond to the West, it was carried out in the Chinese language. Chinese scholars may have mastered English and other languages, but they carried out the reform and nationalism discourse in the Chinese language. The Chinese script being the same across most of the country, the new ideas spread very quickly among the majority Han population. In India, English became the language of interaction among the educated elite who remained a very thin layer, presiding over a highly diverse and multilingual people. The language of modernity was English, and no Indian language came close. In ancient times, it was Sanskrit which had served as the language of the elite in India and in several South-East Asian kingdoms influenced by Indian civilization and culture. However, Sanskrit had ceased to play this role by the eleventh and twelfth centuries, when regional languages began to come into their own. During the Mughal period, it was Persian which began to serve as the elite language, and it was displaced by English only during the nineteenth century.

Awareness among the Chinese elite of the country’s rich culture and intellectual traditions had a continuity, and this legacy was maintained through voluminous accumulation of textual material. In India, there was a steady loss of memory concerning the country’s ancient civilization and culture, though the study of Sanskrit and classical Sanskrit texts was kept